

Clarinet Concerto in E-flat major, Op. 36, 1803; Octet Partita for Winds in F major, Op. 57, 1807; Three String Quartets, Op. 103, 1821

Bernhard Crusell

1775–1838, FINNISH/SWEDISH

Clarinetist and composer Crusell was born in Uusikaupunki (Nystad) in Finland, then part of the kingdom of Sweden. His parents, impoverished bookbinders, were not interested in music, but as a child he learned to play the clarinet and joined a Swedish regimental band at the island fortress of Sveaborg, near Helsinki. In 1792, he was recruited to the Royal Court Orchestra in Stockholm. He played clarinet with the orchestra for the next 40 years, while also winning international renown as a soloist. After studying composition with the German composer Abbé Vogler, he began writing his own works, at first chiefly for clarinet. His output included three clarinet concertos, as well as chamber works for wind instruments. He also wrote vocal music, notably settings of verse by Sweden's leading Romantic poet Esaias Tegnér. His opera *Lilla Slavinnam* (The Little Slave Girl), first staged in 1824, received 34 performances in his lifetime.

KEY WORKS: Sinfonia concertante in B-flat major, Op. 3,